

## DECISION RECORD

# Substitutes for Cilantro Flavoring

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The best solution for people with the OR682 gene who find cilantro soapy is to use substitutes such as flat leaf parsley, basil, or mint, and when adding lemony flavor to these substitute herbs, using lemon zest is preferred over juice.

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## Context

The discussion involved various topics including food shopping habits (buns vs. croissants, bread types), dietary concerns (gluten, nitrates), and taste perception issues related to cilantro. Ziggy provided information regarding flavor changes due to dehydration or freezing of herbs like cilantro.

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## Problem

Che was seeking substitutes for cilantro because they have the genetic predisposition (OR682 gene) that causes them to perceive it as soapy. The discussion also touched upon potential sources of altered taste perception, such as medications and hereditary factors.

## Options Considered

### Using Substitutes for Cilantro

- Ziggy suggested flat leaf parsley with a squeeze of lime, Thai basil, papalo (for Mexican cooking), or celery leaves as substitutes.
- Cost/Risk: None specified; presented as viable alternatives.
- Argument For: Provides similar bright citrusy flavors without the soapy taste associated with cilantro for those with the OR682 gene.
- Argument Against: Che questioned if lemon zest could recreate the flavor, and Ziggy later stated that while parsley with lemon zest is an option, it will be a distinct flavor, not a true substitute.

### Using Lemon to Recreate Cilantro Flavor

- Ziggy stated that lemon alone cannot recreate cilantro's unique flavor profile due to its complex grassy, peppery, and slightly floral notes.
- Cost/Risk: None specified; presented as an impossibility.
- Argument For: N/A (It was a statement of fact).

### Using Zest vs. Juice for Flavoring Herbs

- Ziggy advised using the zest (rind) rather than the juice when adding lemony flavor to herbs like parsley or basil.
- Cost/Risk: None specified; recommended practice.
- Argument For: The zest has concentrated citrus oils that blend better with herbs without adding moisture that could make them soggy.

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## Decision

1. The best solution for people with the OR682 gene who find cilantro soapy is to use substitutes such as flat leaf parsley, basil, or mint.
  2. For adding lemony flavor to these substitute herbs, using lemon zest is preferred over juice.
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## Consequences

- Che has confirmed having parsley and basil available.
- The team commits to understanding that while citrus can add brightness (e.g., with lemon zest), it cannot replicate cilantro's unique grassy, peppery notes.

## Open Questions

- No open technical questions were recorded in this segment.

## Technical Details

- Genetic Marker: OR682 gene variation causes the soapy taste of cilantro.
- Substitutes Recommended: Flat leaf parsley, basil, mint, Thai basil, papalo, celery leaves.
- Flavoring Technique: Use zest (rind) over juice for adding lemony flavor to herbs like parsley or basil.
- Medication Side Effects Mentioned:
  - Clonazepam: Can cause taste changes; 48% of patients report dysgousia, with bitter taste being the most common at 75% of those cases.
  - SSRIs (e.g., peroxidine): Can cause taste changes in about 2% of patients.
  - Other antidepressants: Amitriptyline, bupropion, and trazodone might affect taste.
  - Vyvanse: Can cause dry mouth and reduced appetite; some users report a bitter taste due to decreased saliva production, but taste changes are not listed as a primary side effect.

## Follow-ups

| Owner | Action | Priority |
|-------|--------|----------|
| None  | —      | —        |